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The Semiotics of Embodiment: Radical Orthodoxy and Jewish-Christian Relations

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One of the greatest thorns in the side of Jewish-Christian relations has been contending with and overcoming Christianity's charge that Jews and Judaism remain bound by the flesh in contrast to Christians who, through Christ's resurrection, are elevated into the life of the spirit. This charge, of course, goes all the way back to Paul.^[1] In recent years, Christian theologians have begun reconsidering the doctrine of the incarnation. This issue has captured the attention of two schools of Christian theology; narrative theology and radical orthodoxy. Currently however, only narrative theologians have analyzed how a reevaluation of the body of Christ can advance Jewish-Christian relations. In this paper, I will argue that despite its best intentions, this narrative approach remains supercessionistic. Conversely, despite its failure to attend to the implications of its incarnational theology for Jewish-Christian relations, radical orthodoxy's appreciation of the semiotic character of Jesus' corporeality better links Jesus to the rabbinic tradition's semiotic practices and thereby opens up possibilities for Jews and Christians to study sacred texts together. In what follows I will compare radical orthodoxy's incarnational theology with a portrait of Jewish semiotic life in order to highlight the eucharistic character of rabbinic hermeneutics and the rabbinic character of Christian hermeneutics. Furthermore I will discuss the role of desire within their parallel scriptural practices and articulate how these practices can provide a basis for an ethical and just society.

Narrative Theology and the Eucharist

Radical Orthodoxy and the body of Jesus

Re-viewing Desire

The Donating Community

Jesus' Semiotic Body and Rabbinic Hermeneutics

The Torah and the Nearness of the Divine Word

> Rabbi Joshua b. Levi said: When Moses ascended on high, the ministering angels spoke before

Responding to the story Joseph Soloveitchik says, "God does not wish to hand over His Torah to

> By going back to the Hebrew text from the translations . . . \[one discovers\] the strange o
 open to an entire world^[29]

Moreover, this plurivocal character acts as an invitation, a mandate, if you will for readers

The Semiotics of Torah and Desire

> Scriptural Reasoning therefore emerges out of the dialectic of modernity as the expression o

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Notes

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[^r1] Paul frequently associates Jewish law with a life of the flesh in contrast to the life of faith and the Spirit. See Paul's letter to Galatians, "Did you receive the Spirit by doing the works of the law or by believing what you heard? Are you so foolish? Having started with the Spirit, are you now ending with the flesh? . . . (Galatians 3:3-4).

[^r2] Scott Bader Saye, *Church and Israel After Christendom* (Westview, 1999), p. 142.

[^r3] Graham Ward, "The Displaced Body of Jesus Christ," in *Radical Orthodoxy: A New Theology*, ed. John Milbank, Catherine Pickstock and Graham Ward (Routledge, 1999).

[^r4] Ibid., p. 165.

[^r5] Ibid., p.164

[^r6] Ibid., p.167.

[^r7] Robert Gibbs frequently employs this term when describing the practical events that take place in written and oral discourse. See Robert Gibbs, *Why Ethics: Signs of Responsibilities* (Princeton University Press, 2000).

[^r8] "Displaced Body," p. 167.

[^r9] Ibid., p. 170.

[^r10] Ibid., 172.

[^r11] Ibid., p. 173.

[^r12] Ibid., p. 166.

[^r13] Ibid.

[^r14] Ibid., p. 167.

[^r15] Ibid.

[^r16] Ibid., p. 169.

[^r17] Ibid., p. 174.

[^r18] Ibid.

[^r19] Ibid., 163.

[^r20] Ibid., p. 175.

[^r21] Susan Handelman is perhaps, best known for this charge. See her, *Slayers of Moses, The Emergence of Rabbinic Interpretation in Modern Literary Theory* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1982).

[^r22] See my "Exegesis, Redemption and the Maculate Torah," in *Textual Reasonings*, ed. Peter Ochs and Nancy Levene (SCM Press, 2002) and my "Re-Admitting Philosophy into Contemporary Jewish Thought: An Encounter between Jewish Feminism and Exegetical Jewish Thought," in *On*

Being Human: Women in Jewish Philosophy, ed. Hava Tirosh Samuelson (Indiana University Press, forthcoming).

[^r23] *Shabbat* 88b-89a.

[^r24] Joseph Soloveitchik, *Halakhic Man* (The Jewish Publication Society of America, 1983), p. 33.

[^r25] Elliot Wolfson, "Listening to Speak: A Response to Dialogues in Postmodern Jewish Philosophy," in Stephen Kepnes, Peter Ochs and Robert Gibbs, ed. *Reasoning After Revelation: Dialogues in Postmodern Jewish Philosophy* (Westview Press, 1998), p. 99.

[^r26] M. 'Avot iii, 14.

[^r27] Gen. Rabba i, 1.

[^r28] Ephraim Urbach, *The Sages* (Harvard University Press, 1979).

[^r29] Emanuel Levinas, "Revelation in the Jewish Tradition," in *Contemporary Jewish Theology: A Reader*, ed. Elliot N. Dorff and Louis E. Newman (Oxford University Press, 1999), 166.

[^r30] *Ibid.*, 167.

[^r31] *Ibid.*

[^r32] See my "Re-Admitting Philosophy into Contemporary Jewish Thought: An Encounter between Jewish Feminism and Exegetical Jewish Thought," in *On Being Human: Women in Jewish Philosophy*, ed. Hava Tirosh Samuelson (Indiana University Press, forthcoming).

[^r33] Randi Rashkover, "Exegesis, Redemption and the Maculate Torah."

[^r34] In my dissertation, "Rosenzweig, Barth and the Theology of Election," (University of Virginia, 2000) I discuss the ramifications of Ward's neglect of a doctrine of command and election in the context of my own effort to assess the theological significance of divine command in Jewish and Christian covenantal life.

[^r35] Robert Gibbs, "Why Textual Reasoning?," *The Journal of Textual Reasoning: Rereading Judaism After Modernity*, volume 1.1., Spring 2002.

[^r36] See David Weiss Halivni, *Revelation Restored: Divine Writ and Critical Responses* (Westview Press, 1997).

[^r37] Gillian Rose often launched this critique of contemporary Jewish thought. See Gillian Rose, *The Broken Middle: Out of Our Ancient Society*, (Blackwell, 1992). Nonetheless, Rose could not consider a number of thinkers whose work, written after her death, focuses on the relationship between desire and ethics e.g., David Novak, Miriam Peskowitz, Rachel Adler, et. al.

[^r38] Peter Ochs, "Rules of Scriptural Reasoning," *National Society of Scriptural Reasoning*, 1999.